BRITISH REDCOATS

The red-coated British army was a typical European force of its day, splendidly uniformed, harshly disciplined, and drilled in the use of musket and bayonet. It was composed of regulars enlisted for life, but to raise extra troops for the American war short-term enlistments were introduced and eventually a virtual press gang was instituted. Most soldiers came from the lowest levels of British society and many were from potentially disaffected areas of Scotland and Ireland, but they generally fought with as much determination as any American patriot.

Shipped across the Atlantic, British soldiers entered a hostile and alien environment. The sniping and ambushes employed by rebel militia seemed outrageous to troops trained to fight in the open – one British ensign referred to it as "their skulking way behind hedges and walls". Americans derided the British for parading in bright colours when stealth and camouflage would have served them better. Yet the British were not inflexible in their tactics. They adapted as best they could to local conditions, employing light troops as skirmishers and making small adaptations such as shortening their jackets to prevent their coat tails becoming entangled in undergrowth.

Brown Bess
The Long Land-Pattern flintlock musket, known familiarly as Brown Bess, was the standard British infantry arm from 1722 to 1838. The version shown here was issued in 1742.

LOGISTICS AND SUPPLY

The British unquestionably found American conditions hard. Campaigning on foot across vast tracts of wilderness tended to erode their forces through exhaustion and disease. A large part of their supplies were imported across the Atlantic, and they suffered shortages of everything from food to horses. The Americans proved expert not only at ambush in hilly, wooded terrain but also at field fortifications. In battles such as Bunker Hill in 1775 and Saratoga in 1777, British troops suffered morale-sapping losses in frontal attacks against determined American troops who skilfully exploited natural defensive positions, strengthened by entrenchment and stockades.



Volley fire
British troops were trained to fire in volley and deploy on the battlefield in formal line and square formations. Many were disconcerted by the American snipers and tactics.

Facing rebel activity that extended from Georgia in the south to Canada in the north, the British always had too few men to garrison areas they controlled and simultaneously campaign in strength. The British army that surrendered at Yorktown in 1781 was outnumbered two to one by its American and French opponents.



Battle of Bunker Hill
Redcoats storm the American stockade at Bunker Hill in 1775. The British overran the fortified earthworks on their third assault, but suffered devastating losses in the process.